

Origin essentialism

Advanced Introduction to Metaphysics

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0. Motivating Non-Contingency in Tolerance Arguments

If we only cared about the Sorites-style, “small differences can’t matter” motivation for Tolerance, there would be little point in thinking about Non-Contingency: if the motivation is any good it motivates Necessitated Tolerance. But it isn’t any good.

Fortunately there are lots of cases where Tolerance is well motivated by everyday modal judgments that have nothing to do with the Soritical thought. But these don’t obviously support Non-Contingency. How else might one support it?

- One could try to somehow argue from the premise that we know Tolerance a priori to the claim that it’s necessary. An uphill battle!
- One could argue that the truth of Tolerance at the actual world but not at other nearby worlds would make the actual world “special” in an objectionable way. But how is one to argue that it’s objectionable?
- One could argue that close worlds where Tolerance is false lead to close possibilities where we falsely believe it:

Independence If Tolerance could easily have been false, we could easily have falsely believed it.

Security If Tolerance is true, we couldn’t easily have falsely believed it.

Easiness If Tolerance could have been false, it could easily have been false.

Non-Contingency If Tolerance is true, it couldn’t have been false.

1. Kripke’s argument, and a reconstruction

A principle suggested by these examples is: *If a material object has its origin from a certain hunk of matter, it could not have had its origin in any other matter.* Some qualifications might have to be stated (for example, the vagueness of the notion of hunk of matter leads to some problems), but in a large class of cases the principle is perhaps susceptible of something like proof, using the principle of the necessity of identity for particulars. Let ‘B’ be a name (rigid designator) of a table, let ‘A’ name the piece of wood from which it actually came. Let ‘C’ name another piece of wood. Then suppose B were made from A, as in the actual world, but also another table D were

simultaneously made from C. (We assume that there is no relation between A and C which makes the possibility of making a table from one dependent on the possibility of making a table from the other.) Now in this situation $B \neq D$; hence, even if D were made by itself, and no table were made from A, D would not be B. Strictly speaking, the 'proof' uses the necessity of distinctness, not of identity. However, the same types of considerations that can be used to establish the latter can be used to establish the former.... In any event, the argument applies only if the making of D from C does not affect the possibility of making B from A, and vice-versa. (*Naming and Necessity*, footnote 56):

Strong Sufficiency: For any x and y : if it is possible that x is a table originally made of hunk y , then necessarily any table originally made out of y is identical to x .

Unique Origin: Necessarily, no table is originally made of two distinct hunks.

Weak Compossibility: For any two non-overlapping hunks, if each is such that it is possible for there to be a table originally composed of it, it is possible that both of them originally compose tables.

Hunk-restricted ND: For any two hunks y and z , if $y \neq z$ then necessarily $y \neq z$.

Overlap Essentialism: For any table x and hunks y, z : if x was originally made of y , and y does not overlap z , then it is not possible for x to be a table originally made of z .

1. Suppose for reductio that table x is made of hunk y and possibly made of hunk z which does not overlap y .
2. By Strong Sufficiency, it is necessary that any table originally made of y is identical to x and that any table originally made of z is identical to x .
3. By Weak Compossibility, it is possible that (y originally composes some and z originally composes some table).
4. Hence it is possible that (y originally composes x and z originally composes x and x is a table).
5. So by Unique Origin, it is possible that $y = z$.
6. But by Hunk-restricted ND it is necessary that $y \neq z$: contradiction.

2. Two other reconstruction reconstruction

First reconstruction: replace Strong Sufficiency and Weak Compossibility with

Weak Sufficiency: For any x and y : if x is a table originally made of hunk y , then necessarily any table originally made out of y is identical to x .

Strong Compossibility: For any x and non-overlapping hunks of matter y and z , if it is possible that x is a table originally composed of y , and it is possible that some table is originally composed of z , then it is possible that: x is a table originally composed of y and some table is originally composed of z .

Salmon endorses both Strong Sufficiency and Strong Compossibility.

Second reconstruction (the ‘fat argument’) drop Strong Sufficiency altogether, and replace Weak Compossibility with

Super-strong Compossibility: For any x , u and non-overlapping hunks of matter y and z , if it is possible that x is a table originally composed of y , and it is possible that u is a table originally composed of z , then it is possible that: x is a table originally composed of y and u is a table originally composed of z .

Salmon reports that Kripke endorsed this version in conversation, and it does fit the last sentence of the footnote. But it seems dialectically weak.

3. Plans

Even Weak Sufficiency doesn’t seem very plausible. Couldn’t we make a different table out of this very hunk by radically varying the design? In response, Salmon retreats to:

Plan Strong Sufficiency: If x could have been a table made of a hunk y according to plan P , then necessarily, any table made out of y according to P is identical to x .

This can still power an argument for Overlap Essentialism if we combine it with Weak Compossibility, Unique Origin, ND, and:

Plan Necessity: Necessarily every table is made according to some plan.

Plan Weak Compossibility: If y and y' are non-overlapping hunks of matter and P and P' are plans, and it’s possible that y is made into a table according to P , and it’s possible that y' is made into a table according to P' , then it’s possible that: y is made into a table according to P and y' is made into a table according to P' .

Or you could use ‘Plan Weak Sufficiency’ and ‘Plan Strong Compossibility’.

4. Recycling problems

Problem: even Plan Weak Sufficiency implies that it never happens that two distinct tables are made of the same hunk according to the same plan. But this seems very doubtful assuming “plans” aren’t so specific as to build in a specific time: one can recycle!

Salmon's response: replace the relation *x is a table made of y* throughout with *x is the only table ever made of y*. This gives a valid argument for a weaker, but still interesting, 'only table' version of Overlap Essentialism.

Robertson's objection: suppose table Belinda was in fact the only table ever made of hunk Angus. Surely Belinda could instead have been the only table ever made of slight variant hunk Angus*. But if it's possible for Belinda to be the only table ever made of Angus*, then it is possible that Belinda is the only table ever made of Angus* and later a table is the only table ever made of Angus. But given Weak Plan Sufficiency this conflicts with Unique Origin.

Possible response: replace the relation *x is a table made of y* throughout with *x is the only table ever made of y or any hunk largely overlapping y*. This gives an argument for an even weaker version of Overlap Essentialism.

Is this weakening of Weak Plan Sufficiency plausible?

5. Doubts about Overlap Essentialism

(i) Strawson:

[T]he Old Bodleian ... might have been built of (composed of) stone from quarry A instead of being built, as it was, of stone from quarry B. Will someone say: then it would not have been this building, but another just like it? The retort seems insufficiently motivated. Before the building existed, there existed a plan: a plan for a building on this site, for this purpose, to be constructed of such-and-such type-materials according to such-and-such architectural specifications. Here we have all the prehistory we need. The building, this building, is begotten of a particular project rather than a particular scattered part of the earth's material. If someone said: 'The QE II, you know, might have been built of quite a different lot of steel from that which it was actually built of' — and gave his reasons — would it not be absurd to reply: 'In that case it wouldn't have been the QE II at all — the QE II wouldn't have existed — it would have been a different ship of that name.'? (Strawson 1979: p. 235)

(ii) Special ways of making tables: 3D printing

(iii) Barnett: These using the parts.

6. A different way of arguing against certain Hypertolerance claims

Weak Microphysical Supervenience: Every true proposition is necessitated by some true microphysical proposition.

Strong Microphysical Supervenience: Every possibly-true proposition is necessitated by some possibly-true microphysical proposition.¹

- What's a "microphysical proposition"? Let's not get into it.

Let a *specific* property be one that necessitates *being such that p* for some microphysical *p*.

In a *de re* Tolerance Argument where all the properties involved are specific, and some instantiated property that isn't instantiated by the relevant object *a* is *ancestrally close* to one instantiated by *a*, Hypertolerance conflicts with Weak Microphysical Supervenience. And if two of the properties ancestrally close to one instantiated by *a* are incompatible but possibly both instantiated, Hypertolerance conflicts with Strong Microphysical Supervenience.

- We attempt to construct an argument like this, involving earrings.

7. Coarse Hypertolerance

Note that the Tolerance premises required for Tolerance Arguments where Hypertolerance conflicts with some version of Microphysical Supervenience are much further removed from everyday life than more familiar Tolerance premises. So there's room for a hybrid strategy: accept ordinary ("coarse-grained") Tolerance claims and the corresponding Hypertolerance claims, but reject both Tolerance and Hypertolerance in the cases where Hypertolerance would conflict with Microphysical Supervenience.

¹ Note: a completely different use of 'weak' and 'strong' is common in the literature on supervenience understood as a relation between sets of *properties*.